Cleaning and Maintaining Pet Areas

Details on supporting the cleanliness and order of the pet area in shelters

Typically performed by: *Animal Welfare Partner*
Roles likely to support task: *Facility Manager, HQ Pet Shelter Services Coordinator, HQ Sheltering Manager, Shelter Workers*

Considerations

- Pet owners are responsible for maintaining clean crates for their pets (for example: changing litter boxes, cleaning up and disposal of spilled food or waste).
- Animal welfare partners are responsible for maintaining the overall pet service area.
  - Shelter staff may be asked to assist with basic support such as daily sweeping and mopping.
  - In instances where shelter staff is unable to support, HQ Shelter Managers may consider janitorial services to support.
- Related **Mass Care Groups Standards**
  - Initiating Mass Care Services
  - Prioritizing Mass Care Services
- Related **Sheltering Activity Standards**
  - Shelter Site Operations Standards
  - Household Pets and Service Animals

What to do

Store and use animal-safe cleaning products safely

- Use only animal-safe sanitizing products around animals.
- Carefully follow the specific instructions and cautions for products.
- Never use bleach in the animal room, or on items which an animal may come in direct contact.
- Keep cleaning/sanitizing products and chemicals away from pets. Store them in isolated locations that are not near animals.

Tasks when opening a shelter

- Post signage indicating locations for “Pet Relief Area” and “Pet Service Area.”
- Place waste receptacles in identified relief and service areas.
- Place “pet waste bags” dispenser in the relief area; additional rolls should be available at the reception desk or near the shelter exit.
- Place hand sanitizer in relief and pet service area.
- Provide EPA-registered/veterinary approved disinfecting wipes or spray and follow instructions for use.
- Ensure cleaning tools (broom, mop and approved pet friendly sanitizers) are available for animal welfare partners for use in the pet services area.

Tasks to complete daily

- Cleaning all work tables in the pet services area with approved pet friendly sanitizer.
- Empty all waste receptacles in service and relief areas. Check these locations throughout the day to avoid overfilling/becoming too heavy.
- Sweep and mop floors daily.

- Store pet food securely to avoid attracting wildlife, rodents, and insects.
- Ensure no open food left outside a pet's crate.
- Block rodent entrances.
- Tell your supervisor about any pest or rodent sightings immediately.

Tasks to complete as needed

- Replace preventive items (for example: Floor covering, barriers, etc.) proactively to minimize damage
- Replace worn or damaged receptacles.
- Refill pet waste bag dispensers.
- Refill hand sanitizer dispensers.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Initial Tasks for Opening a Shelter
Priority actions to complete when opening a shelter

Receiving and Obtaining Initial Sheltering Supplies
Steps for workers at shelters to take to obtain supplies for the shelter.

Questions

For assistance contact **Pets@redcross.org**

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